settled in the minds of the voters. And no one in the Congress hierarchy had the appetite to challenge it.

Ramesh later conceded to me, ‘Look, the BJP had an idea of hope that revolved around an individual, Narendra Modi; we had an idea of inclusion that was based on issues like right to food. Their idea won. In an election, someone wins and the other person has to lose—why blame advertising for it?’ Pandey, too, admits, ‘In the end, every successful ad campaign needs a great product to sell. In Modi, we had a terrific Made in India product!’

On 16 May, when the results were announced, Pandey’s team had a small party in Delhi’s Taj Vivanta (formerly Ambassador Hotel) that is located close to the BJP’s 1, Lodhi Estate war room. Three rooms in the hotel had been permanently booked for the advertising executives through the election period. Now was the time to celebrate. As the drinks flowed, there was a banner put up on the makeshift bar. It said, quite simply, ‘Abki Baar’!

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In early June, a few weeks after the election verdict, the Mumbai Press Club held a debate on ‘Did the media create the Modi wave?’ The self-introspection was occasioned by a growing belief that the media had acted as cheerleaders for the cult of Modi. ‘You people have sold out to Modi mania,’ was a criticism I heard throughout the campaign.

The Centre for Media Studies (CMS) claimed in a survey of the election coverage of five news channels (three Hindi and two English) that Modi occupied a little more than a third of the total airtime (33.21 per cent). The next highest was Kejriwal with just over 10 per cent of the news space, followed by Rahul Gandhi with just 4.33 per cent. Regional leaders like Mulayam Singh, Mamata, Naveen Patnaik and Jayalalithaa barely registered on the chart.

In an interview to the media watchdog website, The Hoot, AAP leader Yogendra Yadav complained that the incessant coverage of Modi did give him an incremental vote. ‘I would say if the BJP had finished 5 per cent